

Officer (CTO). The role of an architect in a product organisation will also include one or more of the roles described for a services organisation.

How can you grow as an architect in an organisation? Well, the path for an architect would be: Tech Lead → Architect → Senior Architect → Lead Architect → Chief Architect → Chief Technology Officer (CTO). See Figure 4.

Software architects write code

Did we imply that architects do not write code? Well, that's not exactly the case—the architect does have a role in the coding phase. For example, assume a mobile phone company is running Linux on an ARM platform to create an "A10" family of mobile phones. Let's also assume that there are 10 product variants in this family.

The software architects should have worked on software development in (at least) one of the 10 variants available. They should have customised (at least) one module in the Linux kernel, or worked in the customisation of a feature for (at least) one mobile platform, or any crucial feature of the application software. There are three main reasons for this:

- Writing code helps you to keep in touch with programming and the subtle details.
- You will be involved in brief conversations with the group for coding your module, and this gives the developers a chance to interact with you.
- This will give you an opportunity to follow what you have been telling other developers: writing clean, high-quality and testable code. As Chesterfield would say, "Whatever is worth doing at all is worth doing well!"

We'd like to add that an architect's (call him Murugan) ultimate satisfaction is when the client says—and we quote: "Initially, I wanted to do this work at another company, but now, I am giving this project to your company because Murugan works with you." This means that the company has obtained the work because of the client's respect

and appreciation for one specific architect's capabilities, experience, skills, and ability to deliver!

Let's look at what an architect does when a project is started [3], [4]:

- The architect is involved in collecting requirements and correlating it with his knowledge of the domain and technology.
- After creating the requirements document, the architect works on the architecture document, and completes it with a full review.
- The architect provides a proper estimation in terms of the human resources, time-frame and infrastructure needed for the project. Infrastructure includes software, hardware or both.
- The architect is briefly involved in high-level design and 'hand-holding' when the senior design engineers get into the project, and then moves out of the project.
- The architect is not involved in the day-to-day planning and operations of the project.
- The architect is available for queries by e-mail or phone, and is also available for brief discussions to clarify architecture terminologies. He participates in reviews of project deliverables. He is not involved in detailed design, coding or systems testing. (He could write code for a few important modules, as explained above.)
- The reason is that in a product company, such as in telecom equipment providers OEM (Original Equipment Manufacturer), there will be a family of products that are continuously released, and the architect has to work on creating many such products.
- The architect comes back during the performance and acceptance testing phase to verify that the test cases, relating to non-functional requirements that he had captured in the beginning, are indeed passing.

Architecture document

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